

Συνέσιος ὁ Κυρηναῖος

Synesius of Cyrene on Providence, Dreams, and the Kingdom

eul_aid: sys

Period: Ὀψιμαρχαία [Late Antique](#)

Dialect: Ἀττικίζουσα [Atticizing](#)

Domain: Φιλοσοφία [Philosophy](#)

Format: Πραγματεία [Treatise](#)

Affiliation: [Neoplatonist](#)

Synesius of Cyrene was a philosopher, writer, and bishop who lived during the late 4th and early 5th centuries CE. Born into a wealthy pagan family in Cyrene, in modern-day Libya, he received an elite education in Alexandria under the renowned Neoplatonist teacher Hypatia, whom he deeply admired.

Despite his philosophical background, Synesius became the Bishop of Ptolemais around 410 CE. According to modern scholars, his acceptance of the role was notably conditional; he requested to maintain his marriage and expressed reservations about certain Christian doctrines, such as the literal resurrection of the body. His life exemplifies the complex blend of classical pagan philosophy and emerging Christian identity common among educated elites of his time.

His surviving works, written in refined Greek, cover a wide range of subjects. These include the political oration *On Kingship*, addressed to Emperor Arcadius; philosophical treatises like *On Dreams* and *On Providence*; and literary pieces such as *In Praise of Baldness*, a playful rhetorical exercise. He also wrote *Hymns* that blend Neoplatonic and Christian themes, and a collection of 156 *Letters* that provide a valuable historical record of his era, his thoughts, and his relationship with Hypatia.

Synesius is significant as a case study in the intellectual transition from the ancient pagan world to early Christian Byzantium. His writings offer a unique window into the mind of a late antique figure who navigated dual roles as a Neoplatonist philosopher and a Christian bishop, making his work an important source for understanding the political and religious culture of the time.

Works (10)

- [Καταστάσεις](#) · [Catastases](#) · 10 passages
- [Δίων](#) · [Dion](#) · 25 passages
- [Αἰγύπτιοι ἢ Περί Προνοίας](#) · [Egyptians or-Providence](#) · 40 passages
- [Ὁμιλίες](#) · [Homilies](#) · 2 passages
- [Ὕμνοι](#) · [Hymns](#) · 42 passages
- [Ἐπιστολαὶ πρὸς Νίκανδρον](#) · [Letters to Nicander](#) · 208 passages
- [Περὶ Ἐνυπνίων](#) · [On Dreams](#) · 28 passages
- [Λόγος περὶ Βασιλείας](#) · [Oratithe Kingdom](#) · 38 passages
- [Ἐγκώμιον τῆς Φαλάκρας](#) · [Praise of Baldness](#) · 30 passages
- [Πρὸς Παίωνιον περὶ Δώρου τοῦ Ἀστρολάβου](#) · [To Paeonius-the Gift of the Astrolabe](#) · 7 passages

Other Neoplatonist Authors

- [Ἀμελίου Ἐπιστολή · Amelius Letters](#) · 1 work
- [Ἀμμώνιος ὁ Ἀλεξανδρεὺς · Ammonius of Alexandria Phil](#) · 5 works
- [Δαμάσκιος ὁ Δαμασκηνός · Damascius of Damascus](#) · 7 works
- [Δαβὶδ ὁ Ἀνίκητος · David the Invincible](#) · 2 works
- [Δέξιππος ὁ Νεοπλατωνικός · Dexippus the Neoplatonist](#) · 1 work
- [Ἠλίας ὁ Νεοπλατωνικός · Elias the Neoplatonist](#) · 3 works
- [Εὐσέβιος ὁ Μύνδιος · Eusebius of Myndus](#) · 1 work
- [Ἱεροκλῆς ὁ Ἀλεξανδρεὺς · Hierocles of Alexandria](#) · 1 work
- [Ἰάμβλιχος ὁ Ἀνώνυμος · Iamblichus Anonymous](#) · 1 work
- [Ἰάμβλιχος ὁ Χαλκιδεὺς · Iamblichus of Chalcis](#) · 6 works
- [Ἰάμβλιχος ὁ Χαλκιδεὺς · Iamblichus of Chalcis II](#) · 1 work
- [Ἰουλιανὸς ὁ Ἀποστάτης · Julian the Apostate](#) · 20 works